

Professor Emily M. Suazo

ENGLGS1010_816_2025_3 - UNIVERSITY WRITING

December 2nd, 2025

You Know I Can't Give You the Keys: Liberal Love, Ownership, and the Postracial Lie

In Jordan Peele's film *Get Out*, the moment that turns the whole story inside out is really quiet and almost casual. Chris stands in the hallway of the Armitage house begging Rose for the car keys so they can escape. She digs through her bag, looks up, and says, "You know I can't give you the keys, right?" Until that second, the film has played as an uneasy but familiar story about a Black boyfriend visiting his white girlfriend's comfortable, liberal family. When she refuses, the mask falls. The scene makes something really clear. The real threat is not open hatred. It's affection that turns out to be ownership. This shift actually raises a deeper problem. How do you represent a kind of racism that doesn't sound like racism, that looks like admiration and care, and that even insists it's on your side? *Get Out* is not just about obvious bigots. The Armitages praise Black athletes, collect African art, date Black partners, and brag that they would have voted for Obama a third time. Yet their business model depends on using Black bodies as material for white renewal. Peele has said that he wrote the film during the Obama years, when many people insisted that racism was "over". He calls that era the "postracial lie" (Peele).

In a previous essay I used absurdism and Afrofuturism to think about resistance in a capitalist world. With *Get Out*, I turn to a more intimate problem. What happens when racism doesn't show up as insult or open violence, but as romance, praise, and "inclusion"? I argue that Peele uses horror to solve a representational problem. He shows a form of racism that presents itself as love and progress. To do that, the film puts several ideas into tension: Eduardo Bonilla Silva's "racism without racists," Saidiya Hartman's "afterlife of slavery," bell hooks's belief that "there can be no love without justice," and Sara Ahmed's critique of diversity as institutional

self defense (Bonilla silva; Hartman; hooks; Ahmed). Critics of the film, such as Hannah L. Murray and J. Camille, show how *Get Out* turns the Black body into a site of both desire and control. (Murray; Camille) By putting these voices in conversation with Peele's film, I want to show how *Get Out* prompts us to ask about the intricacies of a society that embraces "Colorness" with the goal of oppressing it even further.

Peele ties *Get Out* to the years of Barack Obama's presidency. In an interview, he explains that the film grew from the feeling that many white Americans treated Obama as proof that the country had moved beyond race, even as subtle racist interactions continued. He describes those years as a time when "we lived in this postracial lie" and says he kept noticing "subtle, seemingly harmless interactions" that showed racism was still active under polite surfaces (Peele). This is exactly the world Chris enters. The Armitages don't shout slurs. Instead, Dean jokes that he would have voted for Obama a third time. The party guests admire Chris's "genetics" and ask if "being Black" is "in fashion." Each comment arrives wrapped in friendliness (44:00). Together they create a thick atmosphere of entitlement.

After the Obama years, we can observe another real world version of this "postracial lie" in the recent attacks on Zohran Mamdani, the Ugandan born, South Asian Muslim who just became New York's first Muslim mayor. News reports describe how opponents called him everything from a "jihadist candidate" to a terrorist sympathizer, questioned his loyalty, and even suggested that his citizenship should be revoked, repeating the same old and awful script that tried to paint Barack Obama as a foreign Muslim who didn't really belong in the country he led (Luscombe; TAAF; Pew; Mechem). What's striking is that these smears didn't come only from the far right. Commentators note a "bipartisan comfort with Islamophobia", where centrist and liberal figures joined in treating Mamdani's African birthplace and Muslim faith as reasons to doubt his fitness

for office, even while insisting they opposed racism in general. The Washington Post wrote: “Prominent U.S. right wingers, including President Donald Trump, tarred the 34-year-old democratic socialist as a supposed ‘jihadist’, a ‘Jew hater’, and a 9/11 ‘cheerleader’.”

Andrew Cuomo, who received Trump’s endorsement, expressed the following opinions regarding Mamdani’s religion: “That job is a scary job... Any given morning there’s a crisis. And people’s lives are at stake. God forbid another 9/11, can you imagine Mamdani in the seat? He’d be cheering. If Mamdani was in the seat on 9/11, what would have happened in this city?” (Al Jazeera; Le Monde; Washington Post).

A similar tension shows up in the language many mainstream outlets use, exposing the systemic problem. Liberal media will label a politician or suspect as “African American,” but almost never describe a white figure as “European American.” Whiteness appears as raceless and normal, the unmarked background against which everyone else must carry a hyphen and a continent (Afropean). *Get Out* visualizes this same pattern. Chris’s Blackness is always named, measured, and probed. However, the racist family is never introduced as “European American.” They are simply the default that gets to decide which bodies are interesting, which cultures are “in fashion,” and who’s allowed to stay or be given the key to leave.

Sociologist Eduardo Bonilla Silva gives me language to further describe this kind of environment. In *Racism Without Racists*, he argues that after the civil rights era, many white Americans stopped thinking of themselves as racist, yet they still support and benefit from a racial order that keeps Black people and people of color at a disadvantage. He calls this “colorblind racism,” an ideology that allows people to say “I do not see race” while explaining inequality through culture or individual effort (Bonilla Silva) A Duke University summary of his work notes that Bonilla Silva shifts attention from “the racists” to “the racism”.

Seen through his framework, the Armitages become a case study in racism without racists. Dean knows how it looks to have Black servants, so he rushes to frame it as anything but racist. His Obama joke acts like a shield. As literary scholar Hannah L. Murray points out, he “fulfils clichés of the liberal” by showing both awareness that something could look racist and a quick defense that marks him as enlightened (Murray). The effect is that Chris has no actual place to put his discomfort. The family works hard to make sure no one can call them racist. At the same time, they literally own the people around them. The garden party scene makes this double move very clear. One guest grabs Chris’s arm to feel his muscles. Another tells him that Black is “in fashion.” Someone else compares him to Tiger Woods. The camera lingers on Chris’s face as he tries to smile through each interaction (00:43:40). These aren’t really insults in the usual sense. In fact, many could be misread as admiration. Yet, as a student project on the film argues, they show “negrophilia,” a fascination with Blackness that treats Black people as objects to collect or consume rather than as full subjects (Dualle and Szeker). The silent auction that follows confirms this reading. The same people who praised Chris’s body now bid on it. Their affection was some type of market research.

Saidiya Hartman helps link this polite horror to a longer history. In her work on slavery and its legacies, Hartman describes the “afterlife of slavery” as the way the old system continues as skewed life chances and premature death for Black people. A New Yorker profile summarizes her idea as the ongoing presence of limited access to health care, education, and safety that raises the question, “Did slavery ever really end?” (Hartman, qtd. in Tolentino). Hartman’s concept insists that slavery isn’t just a past event. It’s a structure that actually mutates and survives.

Get Out does a really nice job at translating that theory into images. The Coagula procedure

turns Black people into vessels for wealthy white clients who want better sight, stronger bodies, or artistic talent. J. Camille argues that the film presents “the Black body as a commodity,” inspired by historical systems like slavery that treated Black people as property (Camille) In this sense, the Armitages are not inventing a new form of racism. They are updating an old one. The plantation has become a suburban estate. The auction block has become a bingo game. The logic remains the same. White comfort and longevity rest on Black capture.

If Hartman emphasizes structure, bell hooks asks us to think about intimate relationships. In *All About Love*, hooks writes that “there can be no love without justice,” and that abuse or neglect “negate love” even when the abuser claims to care (hooks). For her, love is not just a warm feeling but it’s a daily practice that combines care, commitment, knowledge, and respect. Above all, it actually refuses domination.

Rose and Chris’s relationship becomes more unsettling considering hooks’s argument. At the start of the film, Rose appears to be the perfect ally partner. She jokes about her father’s predictable Obama line. She stands up for Chris when the police officer wants to see his ID. She frames herself as someone who understands racism and wants to protect him from it. The key scene with the keys reveals the truth. When Chris pleads, she smiles and says, “You know I can’t give you the keys, right?” Her loyalty has never been to Chris’s safety or autonomy. It has always been to her family’s project. She loves the idea of herself as a white woman who dates Black men. She doesn’t love Chris enough to betray the system that makes that identity and her fantasy possible. In hooks’s terms, whatever feelings Rose has do not qualify as love, because they sit on top of a plan to use Chris’s body. They’re an awful commitment to domination, not to justice.

If hooks helps us see how love can be used for domination, Sara Ahmed's work shows how the language of inclusion can do that work on a broader scale. In *On Being Included*, Ahmed studies how universities and other institutions use the language of "diversity" to manage racism without really changing it. Diversity, she argues, often "is used as evidence that institutions do not have a problem with racism" (Ahmed). The Armitages actually behave like a small diversity institution. Their Black servants, their interracial relationships, and their collection of African art all function as proof that they are "inclusive." Dean even points to how long Georgina and Walter have been "with the family," as if their loyalty cancels the ugly history of Black domestic labor. As Ahmed might say, these signs of inclusion are used to protect the family from critique. They make it easier to say, "We ain't not racist, look at our diverse household!" At the same time, they do nothing to question who holds power, who owns the house, or who controls the keys.

Bringing these voices together shows that *Get Out* is staging a conversation about modern racism. Peele dramatizes the "postracial lie" by filling the Armitage home with compliments and cultural references that never disturb white control (Peele). Bonilla Silva gives that pattern a name in "colorblind racism" and "racism without racists" (Bonilla Silva) Hartman insists that this is not a new story at all, but the "afterlife of slavery" in a different costume (Hartman, "Lose Your Mother"). Hooks refuses to let us call any of this love. Love without justice, she argues, is just another word for possession (hooks). Ahmed warns that even the language of inclusion can become a shield that keeps institutions comfortable rather than changing them (Ahmed). The film's critics extend this conversation. Murray thinks the Armitages are some part of a "US Gothic imagination," where the respectable liberal family hides racial horror under polite manners (Murray) J. Camille interprets the Coagula surgery as a "nightmarish version of future American racism," where Black bodies are sort of like the raw material for white self

improvement (Camille). These scholars help show that the Armitages aren't actually monsters from nowhere. They are exaggerated images of habits that exist in workplaces, elite campuses, and friend groups.

Thinking with all of these writers changes how I see that quiet hallway scene with the keys. At first it reads as a plot twist. The girlfriend is evil, boo! However, once I put Peele in conversation with Bonilla Silva, Hartman, hooks, Ahmed, and the film's critics, the scene becomes a small model of a bigger structure. Chris is asking for freedom of movement. Rose holds the keys and smiles. She insists that she cares about him, but she cares more about the system that secures her family's comfort. Her refusal is not only personal betrayal. It's the moment when liberal affection reveals itself as ownership.

This actually has a lot of stakes beyond one movie. Colorblind racism and the postracial lie continue to show up in institutions that celebrate diversity while defending practices that harm Black people and other people of color. Hartman's question, "Did slavery ever really end?" reminds us that polite inclusion can coexist with deadly inequality (Hartman). Hooks pushes us to measure our relationships, and our institutions, by whether they are willing to give up control for the sake of justice. Ahmed warns us not to accept "diversity" as proof that the work is done. *Get Out* brings these concerns into the space of a horror film and forces them to feel close.

In some way, Peele's film helps us see that the hardest forms of racism to confront aren't actually the ones that call themselves racist. They are the ones that say "I love you" while keeping their hand on the keys. The film suggests that real love, and real progress, would require a different gesture. It would look like handing over control, listening when someone says they

are not safe, and refusing to treat people of color as resources for white renewal.

Citations

Afropean (Illumine, Nat). "Whiteness: Deconstructed." *Afropean: Your Guide to the Afro European Diaspora and Beyond*, 12 May 2019, afropean.com/whiteness-deconstructed.

Ahmed, Sara. *On Being Included: Racism and Diversity in Institutional Life*. Duke University Press, 2012.

"*The Bipartisan Comfort with Islamophobia Harms Us All.*" *Al Jazeera*, 8 Nov. 2025.

Bergman, Sirena. "Hasan Piker Posts Lewd Outburst Mocking Andrew Cuomo After Mamdani Win." *Newsweek*, 5 Nov. 2025.

Bonilla-Silva, Eduardo. *Racism without Racists: Color-Blind Racism and the Persistence of Racial Inequality in America*. Rowman & Littlefield, 5th ed., 2018.

Camille, J. "The Black Body as a Commodity in Jordan Peele's *Get Out*." McLeod Freshman Writing Prize Essay, Washington University in St. Louis, c. 2021.

Dualle, Amina, and Eszter Szeker. *The Sunken Place: "The Post-Racial Lie" Depicted in Jordan Peele's Get Out*. Roskilde University, 2018.

Duke University Department of Sociology. "How Eduardo Bonilla-Silva Changed Our Understanding of Racism." *Duke University Department of Sociology*, sociology.duke.edu.

Hartman, Saidiya. *Lose Your Mother: A Journey Along the Atlantic Slave Route*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2007.

hooks, bell. *All About Love: New Visions*. William Morrow, 2000.

Luscombe, Richard. "The Racism and Islamophobia behind Many of the Attacks on Zohran Mamdani." *The Guardian*, 25 Oct. 2025.

Murray, Hannah L. "Get In and Get Out: White Racial Transformation and the US Gothic Imagination." *Humanities*, vol. 12, no. 6, 2023, article 129.

National Research Council. *Racial Trends and Their Consequences. Vol. 1*. Edited by Neil J. Smelser, William Julius Wilson, and Faith Mitchell, National Academies Press, 2001.

Okeowo, Alexis. "How Saidiya Hartman Retells the History of Black Life." *The New Yorker*, 19 Oct. 2020.

Peele, Jordan, director. *Get Out*. Universal Pictures, 2017.

Peele, Jordan. "Jordan Peele on the 'Post-Racial Lie' That Inspired *Get Out*." *Vanity Fair*, 30 Oct. 2017.

Pew Research Center. "Growing Number of Americans Say Obama Is a Muslim." Pew Research Center, 18 Aug. 2010.

Shamim, Sarah. "Can Trump Strip Musk and Mamdani of Their US Citizenship?" *Al Jazeera*, 2 July 2025.